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ALLEGORY OF CAVE

Plato's parable on perceived reality.

Prisoners mistake shadows for reality; true knowledge lies beyond sensory illusion, in Forms.

Shadows = illusion, sun = truth
Mnemonic: 'escape the cave to know'

[Shadows] —> [Sunlight/Truth]

UTILITARIANISM

Greatest good for greatest number.

Actions are right if they maximize overall happiness or utility for the most people.

Thinker	Focus
Bentham	Pleasure/pain
Mill	Higher pleasures

[Act] —> [Max happiness]

CATEGORICAL IMPERATIVE

Kant's universal moral law test.

Act only according to rules you'd want to become universal law for everyone.

Duty-based, not outcome-based ethics
Mnemonic: 'universalize before you act'

[Rule] —> [Universal law?]

TABULA RASA

Locke's blank slate theory of mind.

Mind starts as a blank slate; all knowledge comes from experience, not innate ideas.

Opposes innate ideas (Descartes)
Mnemonic: 'blank' = born blank

[Blank mind] —> [Experience]

COGITO ERGO SUM

Descartes' foundation of certain knowledge.

"I think, therefore I am" — the one truth Descartes could not doubt while doubting.

Doubt everything except the doubter
Mnemonic: 'To doubt is to think'

[Doubt] —> [Thinking self]

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SOCIAL CONTRACT

Legitimacy of state via consent.

Individuals consent, explicitly or implicitly, to surrender freedoms for order and protection.

Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau key thinkers

Mnemonic: 'contract' = mutual trade-off

[Freedom] <=> [Security]

NICOMACHEAN ETHICS

Aristotle's virtue and golden mean.

Virtue lies in the balanced mean between two vices, extremes of excess and deficiency.

Vice	Virtue
Cowardice	Courage
Rashness	(Balance)

[Excess]<Mean>[Deficiency]

THEORY OF FORMS

Plato: true reality is abstract.

Physical objects are imperfect copies of perfect, unchanging abstract Forms or Ideas.

Forms are eternal, objects decay
Mnemonic: 'Form' = perfect blueprint

[Object] ≈ copy of [Form]

WILL TO POWER

Nietzsche's core human drive concept.

Fundamental driving force in humans is the desire to assert and expand strength.

Not just survival, but dominance
Mnemonic: 'power' drives all striving

[Drive] —> [Growth/power]

EXISTENCE PRECEDES

Sartre: we exist before we're defined.

Humans exist first, then define their own essence through free choices and actions.

No fixed human nature given
Mnemonic: 'exist first, define later'

[Exist] —> [Create essence]

STATE OF NATURE

Hobbes' war of all against all.

Pre-society life is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short" without government control.

Hobbes: chaos, needs strong ruler
Locke: more peaceful, has rights

[No state] —> [Chaos]

GOD IS DEAD YAADCARD.IN	CATEGORICAL VS HYPOTHETICAL YAADCARD.IN	OCCAM'S RAZOR YAADCARD.IN	TROLLEY PROBLEM YAADCARD.IN	EMPIRICISM YAADCARD.IN	RATIONALISM YAADCARD.IN
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RATIONALISM

Knowledge from reason, not senses.

Reason alone, not sensory experience, is the primary source of true, certain knowledge.

Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz key names
Mnemonic: 'ratio' = reasoning first

[Reason] —> [Truth]

EMPIRICISM

Knowledge from senses and experience.

All knowledge derives from sensory experience; opposed to reliance on pure reason alone.

Locke, Hume, Berkeley key names
Mnemonic: 'empirical' = experiment/experience

[Senses] —> [Knowledge]

TROLLEY PROBLEM

Classic ethics dilemma: act or not.

Tests utilitarian vs deontological reasoning; divert trolley to kill one, save five.

Utilitarian: pull lever, save more
Deontology: don't actively cause harm

[1 track] vs [5 track]

OCCAM'S RAZOR

Simplest explanation is usually best.

Among competing explanations, prefer the one with fewest assumptions or entities.

Cut unnecessary complexity away
Mnemonic: 'razor' shaves excess

[Simple] < [Complex]

CAT. VS HYPO.

Kant: unconditional vs conditional imperatives.

Categorical imperatives are unconditional duties; hypothetical ones depend on desired goals.

Type	Example
Categorical	Don't lie
Hypothetical	If cold, wear coat

[Must] vs [If ... then]

GOD IS DEAD

Nietzsche on collapse of moral absolutes.

Modern secularism erodes traditional religious values, demanding new self-created meaning.

Not literal, but cultural decline
Leads to nihilism or new values

[Old values] —> [Void]

SHIP OF THESEUS

Identity paradox: is it still the same?

If every part of a ship is replaced gradually, is it still fundamentally the same ship?

Tests identity over gradual change
Mnemonic: 'parts change, identity?'

[Old ship] —> [New parts]

VEIL OF IGNORANCE

Rawls' thought experiment for fair justice.

Design society's rules without knowing your own future place, wealth, or status in it.

Ensures impartial, fair-minded rules
Mnemonic: 'veil' hides self-interest

[Blind] —> [Fair rules]

PANOPTICON

Foucault: power through constant surveillance.

Bentham's prison design symbolizes how perceived observation enforces self-discipline in society.

Watched or not, behavior conforms
Mnemonic: 'pan' = all-seeing eye

[Tower] —watch—> [Cells]

MIND-BODY DUALISM

Descartes: mind and body are separate.

Mind (non-physical, thinking) is distinct in substance from the physical, extended body.

Mind	Body
Thinking	Extended
Non-physical	Physical

[Mind] ≠ [Body]

SKEPTICISM

Doubting the possibility of certain knowledge.

Philosophical stance questioning whether true, certain knowledge is ever actually attainable.

Pyrrho: suspend judgment always
Mnemonic: 'skeptíc' = 'to examine'

[Claim] —> [Doubt it]

INDUCTION PROBLEM

Hume: past patterns don't guarantee future.

Past regularities cannot logically justify certainty about future events or outcomes.

Sun rose before ≠ will rise
Mnemonic: 'past ≠ proof of future'

[Past] —?—> [Future]

METAPHYSICS

Study of reality's fundamental nature.

Branch of philosophy exploring existence, being, causation, time, and the nature of reality itself.

Meta = 'beyond' physics/nature
Covers being, cause, time, space

[Physics] —> [Beyond]

DEONTOLOGY

Duty matters more than outcomes.

Morality judged by adherence to rules and duties, regardless of the resulting consequences.

Kant's core ethical framework
Mnemonic: 'deon' = duty in Greek

[Rule] —> [Right act]

DIALECTIC

Hegel/Marx: progress through contradiction.

Thisis meets antithesis, producing synthesis — the engine driving historical and intellectual change.

Stage	Role
Thesis	Idea
Antithesis	Opposite

[Thesis]+[Anti]=[Synth]

FALSIFIABILITY

Popper's criterion for real science.

A theory is scientific only if it can, in principle, be proven false by evidence.

Unfalsifiable claims aren't science
Mnemonic: 'if it can't fail, it's not science'

[Theory] —test—> [Fail?]

ABSURDISM

Camus: meaning-seeking in meaningless world.

The conflict between human desire for meaning and the universe's inherent silence and indifference.

Sisyphus: embrace the struggle itself
Mnemonic: 'absurd' = mismatch of hope

[Seek meaning] vs [Silence]

STOICISM

Control what you can, accept rest.

Virtue and inner peace come from focusing only on things within your own control.

Seneca, Epictetus, Marcus Aurelius
Mnemonic: 'control the controllable'

[Control] | [Accept]